University of St.Gallen

Course and Examination Fact Sheet: Spring Semester 2026

8,399: Understanding US-China Relations from Inside out and Outside in

ECTS credits: 4

Overview examination/s

(binding regulations see below)
decentral - Portfolio, --, -- (100%)
Examination time: Term time

Attached courses

Timetable -- Language -- Lecturer
8,399,1.00 Understanding US-China Relations from Inside out and Outside in -- English -- Brühwiler Claudia Franziska

Course information

Prerequisites

A general interest in US-China relations, but also in the respective states as such, and readiness to work with students from another University, in our case Basel.

Learning objectives

At the end of the course, students shall

- have a sound understanding of recent history and key dynamics of US-Chinese relations.
- be able to critically assess ongoing commentary, especially from international media and think tanks, on the development of US-Chinese relations.
- be familiar with more resources such as policy documents for future analyses.
- be able to apply learnings from the background session in debates.
- have honed their collaborative skills in joint projects with students from the University of Basel.

Content

"The future of the world depends on the relationship between China and the U.S.," Henry Kissinger said in 2018 at the 45th Anniversary Gala Dinner of the National Committee on U.S.-China Relations. "China and the U.S. should further seek common interest for the world peace and security." While the first part of Kissinger's statement seems conventional wisdom nowadays, the second part is removed from political reality, with the specter of a second Cold War looming.

Many scholars, journalists, and politicians are still speculating whether US-Chinese relations are bound to be as divisive as US-Soviet relations once were, forcing other states to choose their block. How did we end up in a situation in which many fear a new Cold War? And what factors will shape the future of US-Chinese relations? How are the two states perceiving each other? This class will retrace the history and dynamics of US-Chinese relations, on a political, economic, and cultural level. Building on a sound understanding of said history and of the factors shaping US and Chinese perceptions of each other, students will assess possible future scenarios.

Structure and indications of the learning and teaching design

The course is structured in two blocks, preceded by an online kick-off. Please make sure to be available on the following dates and times:

Kick-off: 2. March, 16h15-18h00 (online)

Block 1: 20 and 21 March, full Friday, Saturday morning (in St. Gallen)

Block 2: 24 and 25 April, full Friday, Saturday morning (in Basel)

The class will be travel from St.Gallen to Basel. Students are kindly asked to consider offering their peers from the other University a couch, spare bed, or mattress to sleep on during their visit in the other town.

Block 1 will be mainly dedicated to the "inside out" perspective, i.e., students learn how the respective systems perceive themselves and how they perceive the world. The first block will build on discussions of mandatory readings and will require students to prepare leading one of the discussions.

In Block 2, we will focus on the way the two systems perceive one another - and what problems arise from these attributions. In preparation of block 2, students will organize in inter-University groups of approx. 4, and work on a creative assignment.

Literature

All texts will be available online on StudyNet.

Additional information

Ralph Weber is Professor of European Global Studies at the University of Basel and is a sought-after expert on the politics of the People's Republic of China. Recently, he and Ariane Knüsel authored *Die Schweiz und China: Von den Opiumkriegen bis zur Neuen Seidenstrasse*. He studied Political Science (politics, economics and law) at the University of St. Gallen and at the Graduate Institute of International and Development Studies in Geneva.

Claudia Franziska Brühwiler is a Professor (Titularprofessorin) of American Political Thought and Culture whose research focuses on the conservative movement and populism. She is a columnist with *Zürcher Tages-Anzeiger*, host of the University of St.Gallen podcast "Grüezi Amerika", and she regularly comments on US politics in German-speaking media.

Examination information

Examination sub part/s

1. Examination sub part (1/1)

Examination modalities

Examination type	Portfolio
Responsible for organisation	decentral
Examination form	Mixed form
Examination mode	--
Time of examination	Term time
Examination execution	--
Examination location	--
Grading type	--
Weighting	100%
Duration	--

Languages

Question language: English
Answer language: English

Remark

Portfolio

Examination-aid rule

no regulation necessary

- For written examinations at home (term paper), courses without credits, etc., no specific rules for examination aids are required.
- The regulations of the University of St. Gallen and the rules of academic work (sources and aids must always be identified) are applicable in a subsidiary fashion.
- All written work must be accompanied by a declaration of authorship.

Supplementary aids

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Content

Students are graded on the basis of a portfolio consisting of

- moderation of a discussion (in groups) in block 1
- hand-written reflection journal covering the entirety of the course
- creative group assignment to be presented in block 2
- active participation

Literature

All mandatory readings will be available on StudyNet by the first session of the class.

Please note

Please note that only this fact sheet and the examination schedule published at the time of bidding are binding and takes precedence over other information, such as information on StudyNet (Canvas), on lecturers' websites and information in lectures etc.
Any references and links to third-party content within the fact sheet are only of a supplementary, informative nature and lie outside the area of responsibility of the University of St.Gallen.

Documents and materials are only relevant for central examinations if they are available by the end of the lecture period (CW21) at the latest. In the case of centrally organised mid-term examinations, the documents and materials up to CW 13 (Monday, 23rd March 2026) are relevant for testing.

Binding nature of the fact sheets:

- Course information as well as examination date (organised centrally/decentrally) and form of examination: from bidding start in CW 04 (Thursday, 22nd January 2026);
- Examination information (supplementary aids, examination contents, examination literature) for decentralised examinations: in CW 12 (Monday, 16 March 2026);
- Examination information (supplementary aids, examination contents, examination literature) for centrally organised mid-term examinations: in CW 14 (Monday, 30 March 2026);
- Examination information (regulations on aids, examination contents, examination literature) for centrally organised examinations: two weeks before ending with de-registration period in CW 15 (Monday, 06 April 2026).